

A Stirling new addition to the Fogg

By Robert Campbell
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"A Queen Anne front and a Mary Anne behind."

That's an old cliché to describe a house on which the owner spent a lot of money on a fancy facade and then economized with a plain backside.

It also describes the proposed new wing of the Fogg Museum at Harvard.

The new Fogg, by British architect James Stirling, is likely to be the most controversial new build-

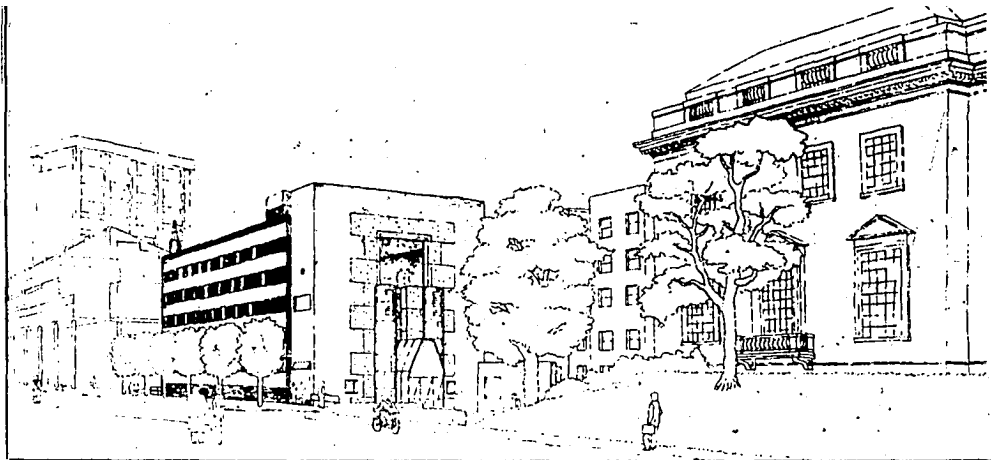
ing in Cambridge since the arrival, 20 years ago, of Le Corbusier's Carpenter Center.

Working with a very tight budget that allowed little room for frills, Stirling has responded by dividing his building into two parts, a front and a back, and putting all the "architecture" into the front.

This front is almost a kind of billboard that stands in front of the building and announces: "Work of Architecture Here." It's composed of various architectural symbols layered one on top of the next to create a kind of collage of the notion of Doorway.

There's a little glass vestibule, for instance, that is almost an entry pavilion. On each side of it are two monumental columns, like those of a traditional doorway portico but without any roof to hold up. Behind these is an even bigger frame of big blocky shapes, like the doorway trim you find in heavy masonry buildings. Finally, viewed as a whole, the front also suggests a triumphal arch.

Everything shouts "grand entrance," but the shout is hollow because the grandeur stops here. The rest of the building, on the exterior at least, is no FOGG, Page A28



Harvard's Fogg Museum and a view of the planned expansion.

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more than a bland brick structure that looks rather like a public housing project of the '30s. Alternating ribbons of brick in two still-unchosen colors are all there is. Small windows are spaced randomly along the darker band of brick. The brick wall curves as it turns around the corner, which makes the design as a whole look rather like a railroad train rounding the bend and heading toward the old Fogg.

It all adds up to a clever conversation piece that is very much of this moment in architectural history. Whether it also adds up to a successful building is a question on which the returns aren't yet in.

James Stirling is one of the world's most celebrated architects. This year, he won the prestigious Pritzker Prize, sometimes called the Nobel prize of architecture. Stirling has been famous among architects ever since his stunning Engineering Building at Leicester University in England of 1963. Over the years, his style has evolved from the high-tech glass-and-gasket manner of Leicester into a less assertive approach in which he works with traditional materials and echoes traditional forms, attempting to weave his buildings into the city around them. For the Fogg commission, Stirling teamed up with the Boston firm of Perry Dean, Stahl and Rogers.

Unlike the odd exterior, the interior of the Fogg addition promises to be brilliant, a gem of dramatic three-dimensional space planning. The design is packed as tight as a suitcase with a variety of functions, all well accommodated. Those little windows in the brick are for offices, classrooms and service areas. Double-height galleries are on the other side of the building and are windowless or skylit. A continuous stair threads its way up through the whole building, connecting everything and promising considerable drama. One of the primary functions of the galleries will be to showcase the Fogg's vast Oriental collections, now largely stuffed away in basements.

The Fogg would like to connect this new wing with its old building across Broadway by means of a high bridge. The bridge would be held up at one end by those two topless columns that frame the entrance. But the bridge requires city approval, which remains uncertain.

In creating his design, Stirling is working with ideas that are very much current in architecture. The elaborate entrance, for instance, suggests the work of the American architect Michael Graves. The notion of a "billboard" front and "boring" back has been advocated by Robert Venturi. The idea of architecture as a kind of readable signage — as in all those symbols of Front Door — is another idea that has been in the air for a while. And Stirling quotes, too, from his own past. The little pointed dunce-cap skylight on the roof, for instance, is casually imitated from Stirling's building at Rice University.

It's always too early to judge a building that hasn't been built. But some things do seem clear. The interior will be an exciting success. The grand entry front will at the very least be fun to look at.

On the negative side, the building seems to have been designed largely from the perhaps rather elitist viewpoint of a person approaching it along Quincy street from Harvard Yard. From there you see the fancy front. Other approaches, just as important, get to see only the brick-striped wall. And this wall is surely a weakness. It's hard to see how so long and dreary a facade can be made to take on life. And it's hard, too, to understand how an architect so concerned with symbol and with architectural "language" can make his museum look, from these directions, so much like apartments of offices.

Both the strengths and weaknesses may be related to the way the architect was chosen.

From the first, the Fogg trustees set out to corral a big-name architect for their new building. They assembled a star-studded list of international celebrity architects from which they picked Stirling.

The Fogg regards Stirling's building as it would a personal, signed work of art, a new "James Stirling" for the Fogg's art collection. Evidence of this is the fact that the museum has mounted an exhibit of Stirling's sketches for the building (on view through June 7). This attitude shows a refreshing and commendable awareness of the fact that architecture is indeed an art. At the same time, it raises its own kind of questions.

A "star" system of rating architects can lead to the kind of one-upmanship and art-market trendiness that infects the world of contemporary painting. And when you go all the way to London to find an architect for Harvard, you give him a subliminal message that you expect a rather special performance.

Stirling has obliged with just that. But in doing so, he has responded (somewhat whimsically) to a context of international media trends

in architecture, rather than to the physical context of Cambridge or Harvard. Harvard's character has never been formed by its special buildings but rather by an austere, repetitive, red-brick vernacular. It would be appalling to imagine a Harvard Yard in which each building was designed by a different star architect.

These are long-standing issues, however, to which there is never a final answer. They don't dim the interest of this exciting building. Construction starts this summer, and one looks forward with pleasure to the opening of the new museum in 1983.



JAMES STIRLING
"A signed work"